



Manđu Macú <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>

(Matzu) Greetings and Questions

4 messages

Al Mánġa Matzú MZYK <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>
To: "pastor@lakestreetumc.org" <pastor@lakestreetumc.org>

Fri, Sep 12, 2025 at 12:11 AM

Hi again. It's been awhile. Matzu, by the way.

How do you find yourself? Much has surely happened since the last time we spoke.

I'm currently attending Normandale College in Minnesota.

Consequently, I am in a writing class that has asked me to write a profile on someone. In particular, someone who means something to me, and someone who represents a type of person, and as I had decided on profiling a pastor, I consider there to be no more relevant a pastor than you for this.

If it isn't too bothersome I have some initial questions:

- What got you into the pastorate?
- What does a day-to-day-by-day look like, particularly, in the buildup to a worship service?
- What goes into writing a sermon?

Detail is preferable. Understand that I will likely have some follow-up questions, and I will attach them as a reply to this email.

pastor@lakestreetumc.org <pastor@lakestreetumc.org>
To: Al Mánġa Matzú MZYK <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>

Sun, Sep 14, 2025 at 7:24 AM

Good to hear from you, Matzu.

I got this on a Sunday morning, my busy time, but I would be happy to reply to your questions later.

Jerry

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Manđu Macú <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>
To: pastor@lakestreetumc.org

Sun, Sep 14, 2025 at 11:48 AM

Thanks for the reply. I await your response.

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Jerry Morris <pastor@lakestreetumc.org>
To: Al Mánġa Matzú MZYK <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>

Sun, Sep 14, 2025 at 2:05 PM

In answer to your three basic questions:

1. *How I got into pastoring.* I responded to a felt "call" to ministry when I was 16 years old. It was at a Southern Baptist camp in New Mexico, at a week focused on International Mission work. (I was there with my parents, who were missionaries to Singapore and were part of the program.) At that time, giving my childhood in Singapore and the

context in which I experienced this sense of calling, I naturally assumed that I too would go overseas as a missionary. I went on to college, and from there to seminary, to prepare myself for that life. In seminary, though, I discovered that I loved biblical scholarship and was quite good at it. I shifted my plans and expectations somewhat, now thinking that I would become a seminary instructor on the mission field. With that goal in mind, I stayed on at my seminary to do PhD work in Old Testament.

But the Southern Baptist denomination was in the midst of a culture war at that time. It was expressed as a theological dispute, but it had more to do with cultural issues than Bible or theology. The more conservative side eventually won, and put into place strict rules against women in any sort of church leadership position and hardening an already-rigid condemnation of homosexuality. As one who disagreed with these (and many other) very conservative views, I was no longer eligible to serve as a Southern Baptist missionary. I taught briefly on a short-term contract at a Southern Baptist university in Arkansas, but that was not going to work long-term either. I ended up out of work for a couple of years, doing odd jobs, before I accepted a call to serve as the pastor of a small Southern Baptist Church in Wisconsin, which I did for seven years. At that point, I made the difficult decision to leave my childhood denomination and accepted a part-time associate pastor's position at a United Methodist Church. That was in 2005. Finding a home among the Methodists, I formally transferred my ordination from the Southern Baptists to the United Methodists. I've been with them ever since. So my journey to the pastorate began with a sense of divine calling, but proceeded by means of trial-and-error and making the most of the circumstances I find myself in.

2. *Day to day as a pastor.* This may vary from pastor to pastor, but when I have done time-studies on my own ministry experience, I generally find that I spend about 40% of my time with administrative tasks (committee meetings, staff supervision, leadership recruitment, communication within the congregation, denominational responsibilities, etc.), about 30% of my time in preparation for Sunday worship service (sermon preparation, working with worship leaders, recording our online worship service, etc.), and the rest of the time is divided between teaching (and preparation), pastoral care (home and hospital visitation, funerals, one-on-one meetings with individuals). It is a constant frustration to me that I spend so much time in administrative tasks and so much less time in things like pastoral care, but the pastorate is a hybrid between *calling* and *job*. The *calling* part is preaching, teaching, and caring for people, while the *job* part is maintaining the institution whose existence gives me the financial freedom that allows me to pursue my calling.

3. *The Sermon Process.* Again, different pastors will follow different patterns, but here is mine. While many preachers follow a standard lectionary with assigned scriptures for each Sunday in a three-year cycle, I tend to preach sermon series of anywhere from 3-8 weeks. I come up with the ideas for these series myself, sometimes from a book of the Bible that I am working through in my own devotional life (e.g. I will be preaching a 6-part sermon series on Jeremiah this Fall), sometimes from a book that I have read (e.g. I am currently in the middle of a series inspired by Charles Taylor's book *A Secular Age*), and sometimes inspired by current events or issues (e.g. a series on "Questions that Deserve Answers" - including the problem of evil, the question of Biblical authority, the question of whether only Christians can be redeemed by God, etc.). Once I have charted out my series and I know where I am going week to week, that gives my mind something to mull over in quiet moments for weeks or months. In my own schedule, I usually make an outline of my sermon on Monday. Then on Tuesday afternoons I key in a first draft of the manuscript. On Wednesday morning I do a first revision of the manuscript, and then that afternoon record the sermon in that form, to be uploaded for our online-only Saturday night service. On Thursday, I do another revision and print a copy to take home. I take Friday off and, if possible, Saturday. Then I do one more polishing of the sermon first thing Sunday morning so it will be fresh in my mind when I present it in the service.

I hope this is enough detail, Matzu. Glad to hear you're well.

Jerry

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